

Like Terms Color Sort

Unit 6: Music Studio • Lesson 6-7 • EduWonderLab

UNIT 6 • LESSON 6-7 • TEACHER NOTES

Standard 6.EE.3

FORMAT Color-code + combine

TIME 25–30 min

GROUPING Pairs

TOPIC Simplify Algebraic Expressions

STANDARD 6.EE.3

PREP LEVEL Light — print expression strips and color guide

Learning goal *I can combine like terms to simplify an expression.*

Teacher setup

- Print one strip set per pair. Students color-code terms by variable and exponent.
- They combine like terms and compare with a partner.
- The organizer keeps constants and variable terms separate.

Materials

Expression strips, Colored pencils, Combine-like-terms organizer, Pencil.

Differentiation & language support

- Organizer columns: variable terms / constant terms (SPED).
- Sentence stem: “I can combine ___ and ___ because they are like terms.”
- ESOL: define “like terms” as “same variable, same power.”

Key vocabulary (English / Español):

Term	Español	What it means
like terms	términos semejantes	terms with the same variable and exponent
constant	constante	a term with no variable

Quick teacher check: *Check Card 3 — students should keep x and y terms separate.*

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Name: _____

Date: _____

Class: _____

Your goal: *I can combine like terms to simplify an expression.*

What you need

Expression strips, Colored pencils, Organizer.

How to play

1. Pick an expression strip.
2. Color each set of like terms a matching color.
3. Combine the like terms.
4. Compare your simplified expression with your partner's.

Expression Strips

Color the like terms the same color, then combine them. Keep constants separate.

1. $4x + 2x + 3$	2. $5a + 3 - 2a$
3. $2x + 3y + x$	4. $7 + 2n + 4$
5. $6m - m + 2$	6. $3x + 5 + 2x + 1$
7. $4y + 2 - y - 1$	8. $8 + 3p + 2p - 5$

Record your work (color + combine):

Explain your thinking

Explain why $2x$ and $3y$ cannot be combined into one term.

Sentence frame: *I can combine ___ and ___ because they are like terms.*

★ **Challenge:** Card 3 has two variables. Write your own expression with x terms, y terms, and a constant, then simplify.

ANSWER KEY

Teacher copy — please do not distribute to students.

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Answers

1. $4x + 2x + 3$ Answer: $6x + 3$	2. $5a + 3 - 2a$ Answer: $3a + 3$
3. $2x + 3y + x$ Answer: $3x + 3y$	4. $7 + 2n + 4$ Answer: $2n + 11$
5. $6m - m + 2$ Answer: $5m + 2$	6. $3x + 5 + 2x + 1$ Answer: $5x + 6$
7. $4y + 2 - y - 1$ Answer: $3y + 1$	8. $8 + 3p + 2p - 5$ Answer: $5p + 3$

Teaching notes & look-fors

- Only like terms (same variable and exponent) can be combined.
- Card 3: $2x + x = 3x$; $3y$ stays $\rightarrow 3x + 3y$.